POEM: MY LAST DUCHESS

FERRARA

That's my last Duchess painted on the wall,
Looking as if she were alive. I call
That piece a wonder, now; Fra Pandolf's hands
Worked busily a day, and there she stands.
Will't please you sit and look at her? I said
"Fra Pandolf" by design, for never read
Strangers like you that pictured countenance,
The depth and passion of its earnest glance,
But to myself they turned (since none puts by
The curtain I have drawn for you, but I)
And seemed as they would ask me, if they durst,
How such a glance came there; so, not the first
Are you to turn and ask thus. Sir, 'twas not
Her husband's presence only, called that spot
Of joy into the Duchess' cheek; perhaps
Fra Pandolf chanced to say, "Her mantle laps
Over my lady's wrist too much," or "Paint
Must never hope to reproduce the faint
Half-flush that dies along her throat." Such stuff
Was courtesy, she thought, and cause enough
For calling up that spot of joy. She had
A heart—how shall I say?— too soon made glad,
Too easily impressed; she liked whate'er
She looked on, and her looks went everywhere.
Sir, 'twas all one! My favour at her breast,
The dropping of the daylight in the West,
The bough of cherries some officious fool
Broke in the orchard for her, the white mule
She rode with round the terrace—all and each
Would draw from her alike the approving speech,
Or blush, at least. She thanked men—good! but thanked
Somehow—I know not how—as if she ranked
My gift of a nine-hundred-years-old name
With anybody's gift. Who'd stoop to blame
This sort of trifling? Even had you skill
In speech—which I have not—to make your will
Quite clear to such an one, and say, "Just this
Or that in you disgusts me; here you miss,
Or there exceed the mark"—and if she let
Herself be lessoned so, nor plainly set
Her wits to yours, forsooth, and made excuse—
E'en then would be some stooping; and I choose
Never to stoop. Oh, sir, she smiled, no doubt,
Whene'er I passed her; but who passed without
Much the same smile? This grew; I gave commands;
Then all smiles stopped together. There she stands
As if alive. Will't please you rise? We'll meet
The company below, then. I repeat,
The Count your master's known munificence
Is ample warrant that no just pretense
Of mine for dowry will be disallowed;
Though his fair daughter's self, as I avowed
At starting, is my object. Nay, we'll go
Together down, sir. Notice Neptune, though,
Taming a sea-horse, thought a rarity,
Which Claus of Innsbruck cast in bronze for me!

Robert Browning

Possessive pronoun *the speaker is laying claim to her as a possession, she is used to better show off his control and power.*

He is making an ***allusion*** *to a famous artist of the time. The suggestion is that he values the name of the artist more than the Duchess it is a painting of.*

He is showing his power in the ***bracketed aside*** *by suggesting that he is giving the messenger a rare privilege to see the Duchess in this way, exercising his control. In fact the* ***irony*** *is that he needs to show off.*

If they 'durst': If they dare, he is showing off his power again and how others fear him.

He ***implies*** *that people believed it was not only him who could make her happy (though he couldn't) the 'spot' is a* ***pun*** *between a mark, showing her face had some joy in it, but also spot as in a small amount, she was not happy. Hints he was jealous.*

Sinister tone*, 'dies along her throat' the words are also* ***semantically linked*** *to murder 'die' and 'throat'.*

He is trying to be polite, using a ***rhetorical question*** *to indicate a lighter tone to the conversation, in fact he is trying to avoid showing his jealousy and rage, at conflict with himself.*

He is angry that she would find the same level of joy in the expensive gifts he bought her and the cheap or simple gifts of the poor or nature. Angry at his lack of control. He juxtaposes the two things though the irony is that his are without sincerity.

Exclamation *and change of structure, the verse is broken with* ***caesuras*** *to show his rising anger. He is losing control, his personality now angry when it was calm.*

The poet is ***ironically mocking*** *how vain the Duke is, he cares more about his heritage and cannot understand that she did not see that as important.*

Here he clearly states how even if he was good with words and could ask her to stop giving everyone else so much attention, he would choose never to stoop so low. He is showing his believed power as above asking for things from women. ***Ironically*** *she is in control.*

The use of ***semicolons*** *gives a sense of finality to the statements. It is suggesting she was killed on his request. This is the culmination of the* ***conflict*** *in the relationship. Euphemism to suggest the fact she was killed?*

Her in a painting satisfies him as much as she did in real life, as a possession. The question shows a change of ***tone*** *to return to the civil and polite way in the start. This helps give the poem a circular structure.*

Dowry, money paid by the brides parents. Suggests he is more interested in the money than his planned future bride. It is sinister as is again suggests a repeat in his actions. Munificence means generosity. He is counting on being given the money.

As with the start he uses an ***allusion*** *to another famous artist in order to show off his wealth and power. It is used to show how he quickly forgets about his dead wife who he was previously claimed to be so devoted to. Ironic as he has just also been talking about how devoted he will be to his new wife. Gives the poem a circular structure.*

The portrait above, largely believed to be the last Duchess.

Context:

Robert Browning was a poet in the 19th century. The son of a wealthy bank clerk, he didn't fit in as much in London society, he left the country and went to Italy to marry fellow poet Elizabeth Barrett because of her over protective father. As a result they were both familiar with over controlling patriarchs in the family as well as Italy itself.

The poem is loosely based on the Duke of Ferrara and is written from his perspective, talking to a messenger about arranging his next marriage. The assumption being that he was dissatisfied with his former wife and had her killed.

Alfonso Duke of Ferrara

Themes:

The idea of Power and Conflict is shown in the way the speaker (the Duke of Ferrara) is showing off his power and also suggesting the control he had over the Duchess's life. There is also conflict between who he presents or wants himself to be and who he really is as a character.

Structure:

The poem is an example of **dramatic monologue** (a speech given by one character). It uses a large number of pauses (**caesuras**) in the poem along with lines that flow into one another (**enjambment**) in order to try and capture the tone of the speaker talking away to the messenger and adding in tangents (small opinions and asides). The poem uses **rhyming couplets** and **iambic pentameter** this reflects the style of **romantic poets** at the time, despite how this poem is much more sinister and dark. It is another façade for the Duke of Ferrara's character. You will note he is the only character that speaks despite the fact he is talking to someone, he never lets them speak.

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-Look up a bit more information on Duke Alfonso of Ferrara, see if it helps you understand the character.

-The poem is better as a speech, imagine yourself as a self centred rich man, how does it sound to read it aloud.

By the end of this you should know:

Higher Marks	Lower Marks
-The poem is a dramatic monologue with the Duke of Ferrara arranging his new marriage but getting swept up talking about his former wife. *-The change in tone is used to show the sinister undertones and power struggle in the relationship, he is the only one truly at conflict here.* *-The poet ironically shows that his man is rich and educated yet a fool in matters of love and honesty, both powerful and*	*-The poem is spoken by a Duke and talks about his last wife.* *-He is normally polite but the more talks about her, the more he becomes jealous.* *-We see that he is a powerful rich man but was in fact he could not control his wife, he was at conflict even though she was not trying to anger him.*

Space for your notes: